

Researcher Journal

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Class: AP Research

Organizational Method: Chronological by date.

February 3, 2026 (Long)

Today I finally pinned down what the Topic Proposal was supposed to do. My first draft attempted to touch upon TikTok, Instagram, mental health, authenticity, and other topics related to social media platforms. However, upon closer inspection it was five different research papers in one. Thus, I returned to my inquiry notes, my poster notes, and the various handouts from class and wrote the following sentence on a blank page:

I want to study what the pressure of view counts does to small content creators on platforms like TikTok and Instagram.

I arrived at this specific example of the challenge of view counts after noticing that on several editing videos on TikTok last night, the edits used the same text for the caption on screen, the same hook within the first second of the video, the same dramatic pause in the middle of videos, and the same tags placed underneath the caption of each video. These elements all pointed to small creators who were changing the nature of their content with the intention of receiving views from their audience. Thus, I am interested in the phenomenon of small creators because they are more likely to feel the pressure of producing views as their audience is smaller and they are unable to absorb the bad posts from individual creators. Thus, I can investigate the impact of small creators who experience poor view counts for their content compared to those with larger followings.

February 6, 2026 (Short)

Today I searched for the following terms: algorithmic gatekeeping creators, TikTok creator stress views, Instagram low reach small artist, and social media visibility anxiety. One of the notes I saved from a Reddit thread stated: "I spent four hours on a painting post and 20 minutes on a trend post, and guess which one got pushed." This sentiment was useful for exploring the impact of different types of social media posts on creators.

February 10, 2026 (Long)

Today the Topic Proposal was due. While writing the Topic Proposal I had to contend with my use of the term "algorithm." The algorithm, in this case, referred to the rankings of content within social media platforms, the recommendations for the content that would be visible to creators and their audiences, the visibility of each creator's posted content, and

whatever hidden rule system that each social media application used to determine which creators would be seen by the audiences on the platforms. Both Gillespie and Bucher held particular significance within this research project. Gillespie provided information regarding the concept of “gatekeeping” within social media content platforms. However, Bucher explained the emotional response that is felt by the creators when they feel as if they are becoming invisible within their platforms.

I referenced the following Instagram reel for my Topic Proposal: a small digital artist created a video for her channel that showcased one drawing that she had put a lot of effort into creating and then another drawing that she had created using trending audio on Instagram. Within the video she stated: “This one took me six hours. This one followed the sound everybody is using. Guess which one got reach.” This statement from the digital artist provided an example of the way that creators are responding to the rankings of their content and the view counts of their content by changing the way in which they create their content.

Furthermore, I explained within the Topic Proposal that I wished to investigate the reason that the creator begins to feel as if their preferences in content creation are incorrect after they experience low view counts. Thus, their view counts begin to influence the decisions that they make within the content that they create.

February 12, 2026 (Short)

Today I played with splitting up the Problem Statement into two separate parts within my notes. This was to assist me in avoiding the blurring of these two elements of the project. The first problem statement that I wrote was that social media platforms use algorithms to control the visibility of creators content. The other problem that I wrote was that as a result of this visible control over the content of creators, those creators begin to feel emotions towards their platforms and begin to change the content that they release.

February 17, 2026 (Long)

The reason that Academic Paper Sample A was of any use to the research project was because it contained definitions of the research topic, where it will be studied, and the reason for the study. Thus, it forced me to define these elements of the project within the paper. For instance, within the Literature Review Preparation I defined each of the authors that I would be citing in this project:

Gillespie discussed the concept of ranking and the relevance of the content to the platforms algorithms and audiences.

Bucher provided insight into the emotional response that is exhibited by content creators within the platforms that they operate within.

Bishop discussed the theories that are created by the creators within the comment sections of the content of those platforms.

Eslami explained how the creators of social media content often misinterpret the content that they create and the reasons for its view counts based on their own assumptions regarding the popularity of their posted content.

Each of these statements provided insight into why each of these authors were cited within the research project.

Furthermore, another example that I cited within my notes was from another content creator who was discussing her decision to delete a video that had amassed only around 300 views. She stated within her video: "I know that the video that I deleted was my favorite but the application clearly did not like it." This quote was cited within my notes to provide an example of the way in which the creators begin to feel as if their own preferences are incorrect and they begin to change the content that they create as a result.

February 19, 2026 (Short)

I spent some time working on the Literature Review Preparation for this project. For instance, I made adjustments to the source chart for the sources that I will cite within this project. I also cited within the Bishop article that "algorithmic gossip" is used as an explanation for the information within her article. Within the comment sections of posts on social media platforms, creators share information that they have gathered from other creators that they feel has an impact upon their content and their audiences. For instance, information that is shared within these comment sections can include advice such as to post at specific times of the day, to delete their content after it has been posted, and to use specific hashtags within the posts. None of these suggestions are official suggestions from the platforms but many of the creators follow them.

February 25, 2026 (Long)

The Survey Critique helped to reveal for me in what ways I was potentially placing words into the mouths of the creators that I was surveying. For instance, one of the questions was: How has the algorithm harmed your creativity within the past year? This question is inappropriate for a variety of reasons. For instance, the word "harm" implies some type of negative impact upon the creators' abilities to be creative. Furthermore, the question assumes that the creators are aware of the negative impact upon their creativity due to social media platforms algorithms. Thus, I reworked the question into two questions:

Have you ever changed the content that you posted on social media platforms like TikTok or Instagram due to your view counts of your content?

If you have changed your posted content, what changed about that content that you posted?

These questions are general enough to be answered by the participants of the survey but narrow enough to gather useful information regarding the reason that creators change the content that they post.

I had to catch up on schoolwork due to missing class earlier in the day. When I entered the school on that day, I was immediately plagued by the “everyone else knows what is happening but me” feeling. Thus, for instance, I spent part of class catching up on my inquiry proposal comments and part of lunch working on the survey on my phone. When I returned to school later in the day, however, the slowdown in the project helped me to organize my survey into four separate elements that will be studied within each stage of the project. First, what type of content did the creators post on social media platforms. Second, what happened to that content on social media platforms. Third, how the creators within the survey analyzed the reason for the view counts of their content. Finally, what the creators did with their content after they analyzed their view counts. These four elements will form the basis of my research study. Furthermore, I also returned to Reddit and some of the discussion posts from other creators who posted content on platforms like TikTok and Instagram. For instance, one creator stated that her content that included serious art received 212 views while the trending content for the week received 4,800 views. Furthermore, another creator stated that they began to place emphasis upon the trending audio content for their videos rather than their content because the trending audio content receives more views.

February 27, 2026 (Short)

Today, through completing both the Method Brainstorm and the Data Analysis and Method Examination, I began to understand how the survey would help with analyzing the creators and the interviews with those creators would help with observing the reason for the creators decisions to create the content that they did.

Furthermore, today I decided on the criteria for the creators that I would interview. I would like to interview small content creators who use social media platforms like TikTok and Instagram, who have active accounts with a small following, and who create their own content instead of the content of other creators that they follow.

March 3, 2026 (Long)

Today I completed the Inquiry Proposal Form for this project. Within the Inquiry Proposal, Dr. Kenny asked that I ensure that the purpose of the project, the research question that will guide the study, and the method that will be used to investigate the topic all be in alignment. Thus, I had to ensure that my research question matched the other two

elements of the proposal. I had been investigating the impact that requiring content creators to experience a certain number of views has upon their content creation but I had not clearly defined the method in which I would investigate this question. Thus, I had to rework my project to ensure that my question related to the reasons that the view counts of creators have an impact upon their decisions.

For instance, my current rewording of the project is that I will investigate small creators who use platforms like TikTok and Instagram. Specifically, I wish to determine the impact that exposure to low view counts for their content, changing analytics of those view counts, or the pressure to create content that follows trending audio impacts their feelings towards creating content and the type of content that they will create for their audiences.

Furthermore, I also had to adjust the criteria for the creators that will participate in the survey to ensure that I was not introducing any potential biases into the project. Thus, instead of selecting small creators as I had first defined, I am adjusting the criteria for the creators to those who are beginning to build audiences with their content on social media platforms but who have not yet gained massive followings of content creators who are willing to perform the type of content that they create for their audiences.

While this might seem like a relatively vague statement, it will be further defined within future proposals for this research project.

March 6, 2026 (Short)

The ethics of the project were something I had to think about very hard today. The identity of the creator is part of the issue. For example, if a creator says they changed their art style or deleted posts because they were getting low reach, I could not just casually include that in the project with their handles. I wrote myself a note to ensure that their identities would remain anonymous.

March 10, 2026 (Long)

The poster project allowed me to decide on which boxes I would include in my project. The components that I had to consider included "The Problem," "Research Question," "The Method," "The Gap," "Safety & Rights," and "Next Steps." Each of these components had to be considered to ensure that there was no repetition of the same topic in two different boxes.

One of the boxes that I spent the most time in was the "The Gap" box. For example, instead of just stating the general idea that nobody talks about how small social media creators feel about the pressure to gain views, I specifically talked about how most of the literature discuss how the algorithms cause the visibility of creators content to be subject to anxiety but does not discuss the feelings of those brand new creators just starting out in building their social media accounts and finding their identity as creators.

After school, I watched a portion of the documentary The Social Dilemma, after which I returned to my favorite social media channel for creators on TikTok. Three of the videos discussing various topics for creators talked about the first 30 minutes after posting a video. One creator stated that he or she would reply to comments on the videos to “wake the post up.” Another creator said that he or she would avoid editing the captions after publishing the videos because it would “confuse the system.” The third creator said that he or she would pin a comment to the video that posed a question to the viewers to keep their watching time on the video. Each of these comments allowed me to understand one of the behaviors of the creators that Bishop studied.

March 12, 2026 (Short)

The elevator pitch about the project helped me to find the best sentence to introduce the project and the topic: I am studying how the pressure that creators feel to receive views from their audiences changes what they feel and what they decide to create and post. I also recognized that my methodology using surveys and interviews felt weak because I was aware that I would have to find these creators and ask them to explain their behaviors.

March 13, 2026 (Short)

Another snow day allowed me to catch up on my favorite anime, One Piece, while also practicing the interview questions that I would have to ask the social media creators. However, rather than improving the interview questions, I became more annoyed at the project structure and the need to find these creators to ask them the questions. Instead, I saved four videos from creators that discussed their issues with low reach, creating new trends in their videos, and changing the content that they posted to try and gain more views.

March 16, 2026 (Long)

For the Creating Instruments for Data Collection portion of the project, I found that it took me longer than I should have due to the necessity of deleting questions. For instance, I eliminated the question that asked the creators if social media had damaged their authenticity. Another question that was eliminated was the question that asked the creators if they felt that they were being controlled by the social media platforms algorithm. Both of these questions were eliminated because they seemed to be too dramatic to be relevant to the project. Instead, I created questions that asked about their social media platforms, the number of their social media followers, the metrics that they use to evaluate their videos, if they have ever changed or deleted any social media posts due to the views that they received, and if they can describe an example of one of these instances.

When I looked at the questions that I had created instead, I recognized that I would have to ask these creators to provide answers. I would have to find these creators, ask them the questions, and ask them to describe their behaviors. Instead, I can find videos of creators discussing their experiences with these exact topics. I had to change my methodology from interviews to discourse analysis.

March 18, 2026 (Short)

For the Data Analysis Practice portion of this project, I used the social media videos and comments from the creators to form specific codes regarding their experiences. I coded each of these creators according to categories including stress after receiving low views to social media platforms, the behavior of changing social media posts, following social media trends, changing the audio for their videos, changing the time that they posted to their social media platforms, the feeling of blaming the social media platform for their lack of views and success with their videos, and the feeling of the creators of the quality of their videos and their content.

Based on the coded answers from these creators, I realized that I did not want to use the survey any more for the interview of these creators.

March 20, 2026 (Short)

On this day, I had my poster presentation and elevator pitch to other students. The portion of my presentation that allowed me to connect most with the other students was when I provided an example of how the creator may make one video that they liked to publish but make another video that includes a trending song to try and gain more views. These two types of videos would result in the creator receiving two different types of views of their videos. Furthermore, after presenting my project to others, I realized that I should stop asking the creators in the interview for their answers to the survey and just analyze the videos that the creators have published of their own experiences.

March 24, 2026 (Long)

Today I worked on the Introduction and Literature Review but did not submit the paper. While break is here, I did not have time to complete the Introduction and Literature Review in time. Furthermore, I will need to ask two other students to review the topic for me before I can turn it in. Since all of the students have left the classroom, however, the introduction and literature review will remain on Google Docs until school days begin again.

Furthermore, I have changed the methodology for this project. Instead of asking the interview and survey questions of the creators, I have eliminated these entirely. I had to ask the creators to participate in the interview and to answer the questions on the survey.

However, as I looked at the project and creators videos, it became clear to me that instead of asking these questions of creators, I could simply analyze the videos that they have created and presented in which they explain their reasons for their decisions for their videos.

For the Literature Review portion of the paper, I had to ensure that each of the sources that I cited related to my research question and my topic for investigation. For instance, I had to eliminate any explanations of the social media platforms in general and any comments on the reasons that creators feel like they are being mistreated by those platforms. Instead, I have to ensure that any explanation of the topics relates to the feelings of the small creators of the reasons that they feel pressure to gain views but feel that they experience disadvantages in comparison with other creators.

Another portion of the paper that I had to adjust was coming up with a clear definition of the term "small creators." For instance, while a small creator on TikTok may have 500 followers, another small creator on Instagram may have 5,000 followers. Both may feel as "small" as the other but they are not experiencing the same challenges. This clarification of the topic and term will be completed before finalizing the Literature Review portion of the paper.

Furthermore, I had to attach specific ideas to specific claims in the paper to make it look less like a dramatic opinion of the entire topic but rather a legitimate research paper. For instance, any mention of the topic of ranking in social media platforms will be associated with the work of Gillespie. Any mention of the feeling of fear of creators of disappearing from view to social media platforms will be associated with Bucher in my paper. Creators trading advice in the comments of their videos will be associated with Bishop's discussion of the topic. The potential for creators to begin to misunderstand the actions of social media platforms will be associated with the work of Eslami. Furthermore, the idea of small creators beginning with a disadvantage in relation to visibility on social media platforms will be associated with the information regarding the cold-start phenomenon in social media.